

account (and even run up overdraft fees) by the time you notice the money is missing.

To make sure you don't get cleaned out, don't give anyone your PIN number, consider using the signature system whenever you can, and check your bank statement every month to see that it squares with your own records.

- **Ask your current card company for a better deal.** You may be able to talk your bank into lowering your rate or eliminating your annual fee, but you'll have to speak to an actual human being to get results. Call the toll-free number and ask for the "retention office." Explain in a friendly but assured manner that you're thinking of canceling your card if your request isn't met. Say that your other cards have lower interest rates and no fees (but be prepared for the phone rep to ask you to name names). There's a chance the rep will check your record and offer you some break on the rate or fee, if you've been paying your bills on time.
- **Open and read the mail your credit card company sends you.** Even if you're getting your monthly credit card statement online, you may still get old-fashioned paper mail from your issuer. Sometimes it's just little notices and advertisements, but sometimes it may be an important announcement from your credit card issuer. The company could be letting you know, for example, that it's charged you overdraft or late fees, lowered your credit limit, or raised your interest rate—it has to give you a written warning, and this may be the only notification you get. So when you get any mail from your credit card company, make sure you read it so you know your card's current rules.
- **Don't use your credit card for cash advances.** Most credit cards can be used to obtain cash from an ATM. When you use a credit card for a so-called "cash advance" from an ATM, you're borrowing money from the credit card company in a more expensive way. That's because many